



Language can be
conFusing For me.

It takes me longer than
the average person to process
conversations.

And although I am good at
making conversation, it can take
me longer than normal to respond.

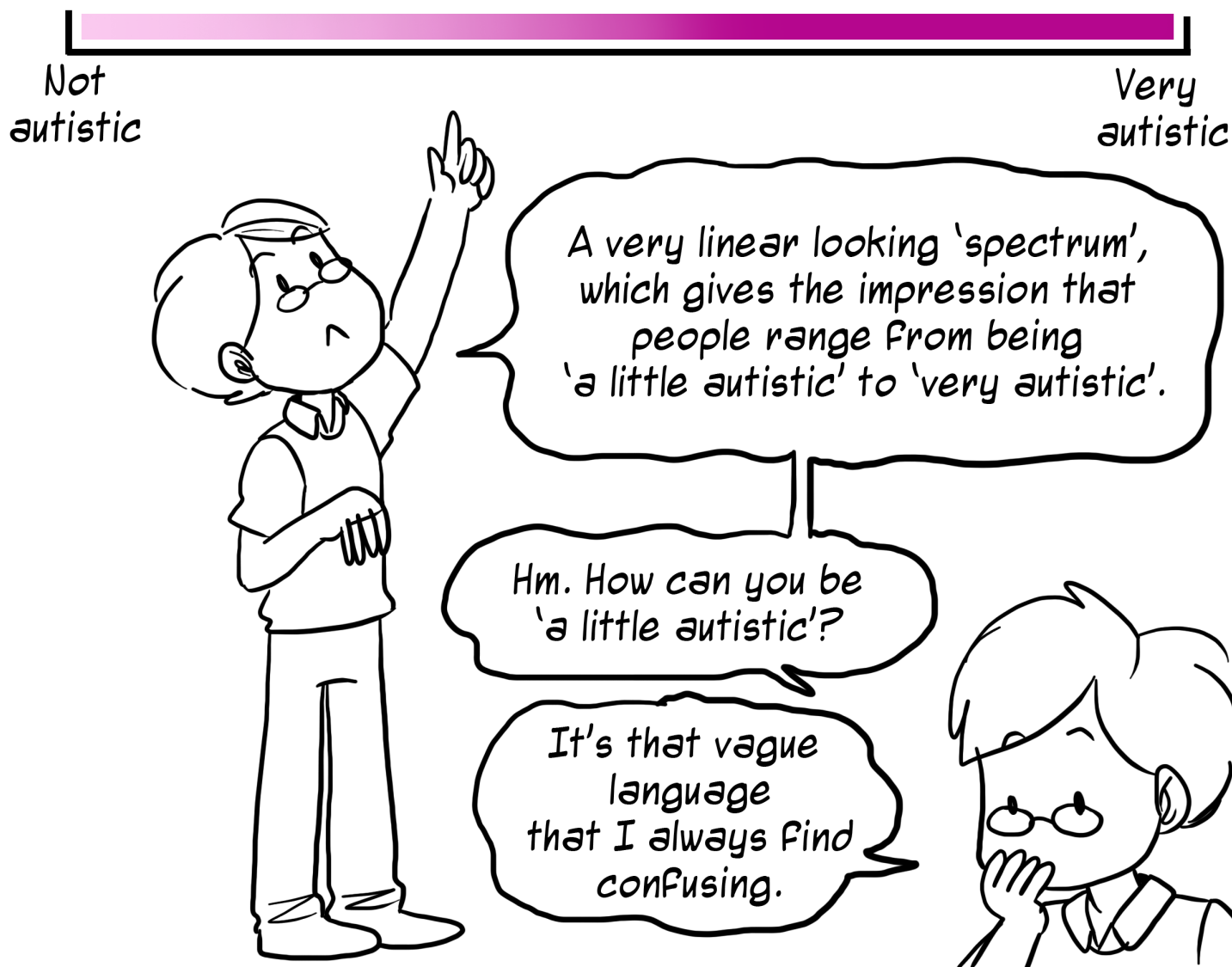
But, neurotypical
people find
language
conFusing too.
And it can lead
to some people
mispercieving
who I am.





That is why I would like to explain what is meant by 'spectrum' when we talk about the 'autistic spectrum'.

Sometimes when people think of this word, they think of the autism spectrum as being like this:



The problem with thinking of the spectrum in this way, is that a perception of an autistic person also becomes linear.



You're only a little autistic, Archie.

Hm. I still don't understand, can you be less vague?

You're able to have a normal conversation with me and act pretty normal! You're not *severely* autistic.

Not autistic

Very autistic

...And so you see, if someone thinks you're on a 'low end' of this spectrum, this often happens:



Archie you can handle all of this just fine, you're not *that* autistic.



NEW Situations
TOO MUCH NOISE
LACK of ROUTINE
'SMART' tight clothing
DON'T STAY
loads of conversations all at once
DON'T FIDGET
BE MORE ORGANIZED!



Ah.

Ahh-

ACT LIKE EVERYONE ELSE BUT CONCEAL IT

How can you be tired? everyone does this every day, you're just being lazy.

Aah!

BUT CONCEAL IT

HARDER AND LOOK NORMAL WITH OTHERWISE PEOPLE GETTING ANCE

Aaah!

Wow you're being so over dramatic, get over it!

Woah, you're more autistic than I thought.

And if you're seen as being on the 'high end' of this spectrum-

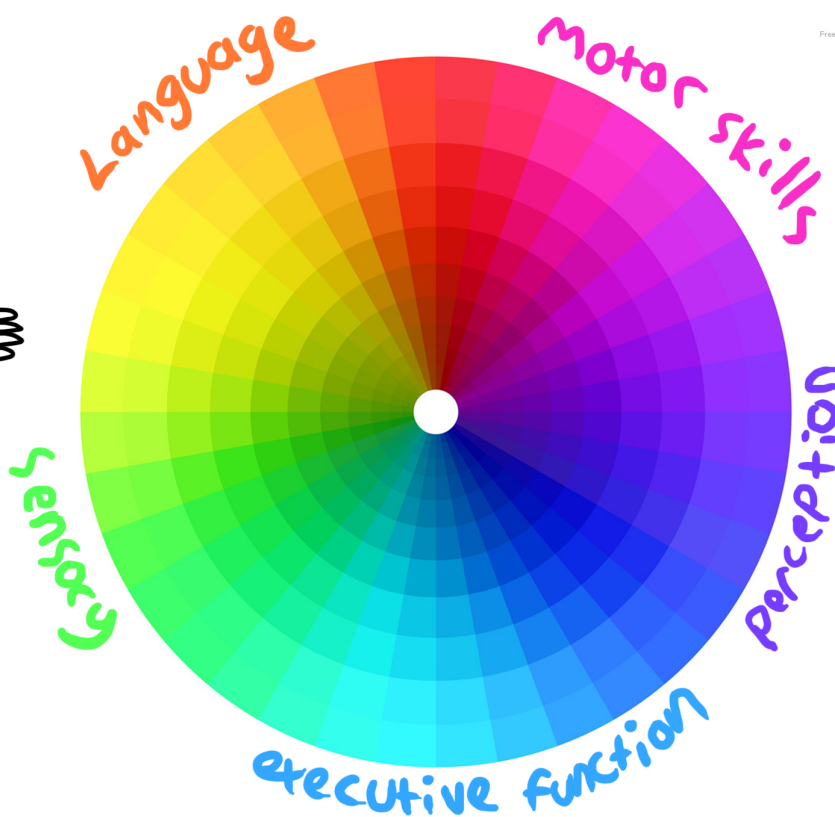
I'm gonna re-label you on this spectrum... Since you're very autistic I don't think you should have a job, just to be safe y'know?

It can lead to some people labeling you as being incapable of doing anything at all.



Not autistic Very autistic

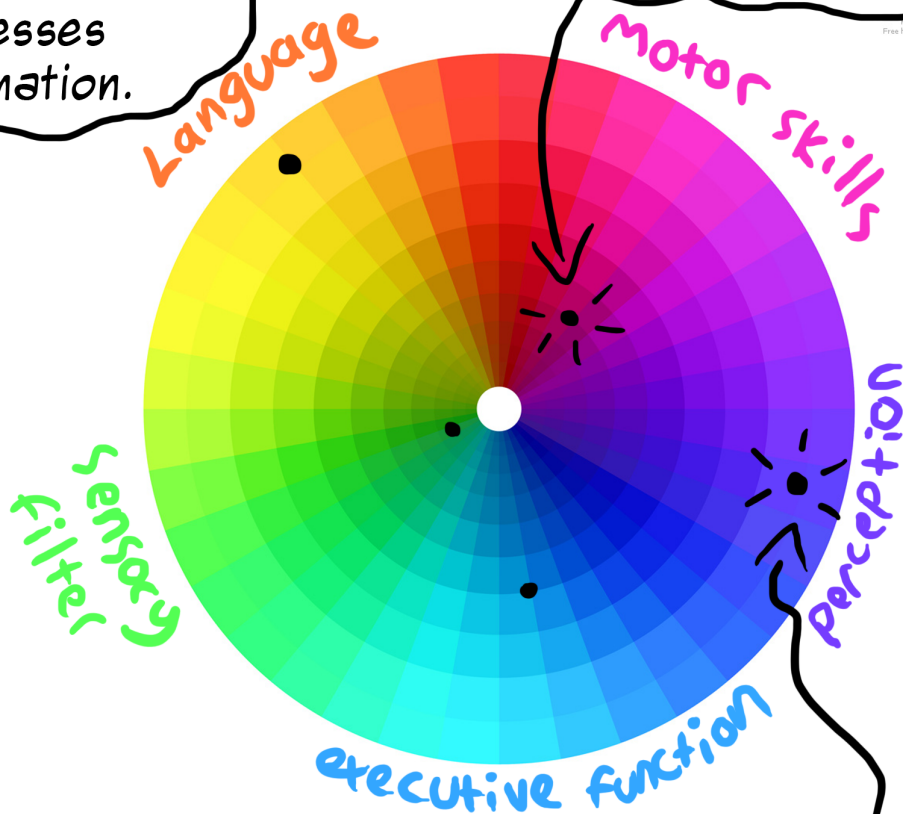
The truth is though, someone who is neurodiverse in some areas of their brain, will also be no different to your average person in other areas of their brain.



You see, the autistic spectrum looks something more like this.

The spectrum consists of many different 'traits', or ways in which the brain processes information.

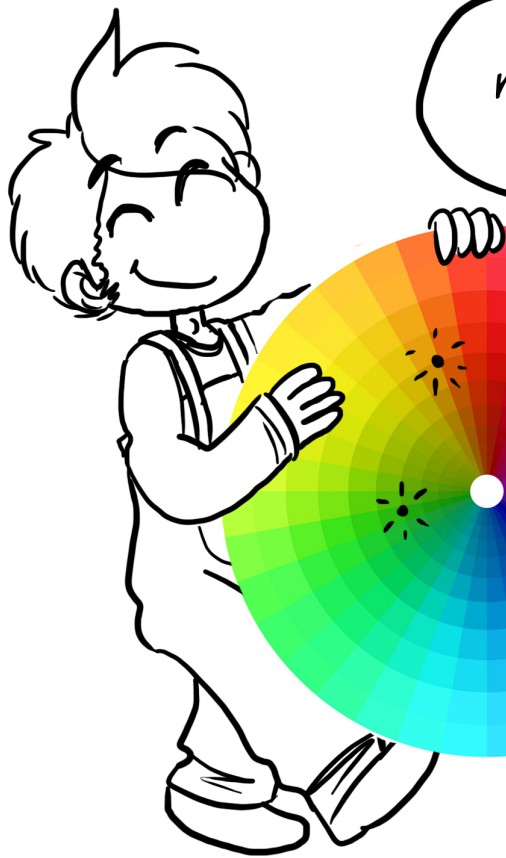
Some traits create difficulties in every day life. (hence being diagnosed)



But also many traits are useful in every day life.

Each person with autism will have a set of traits all in different areas of the spectrum. The areas where they don't have a trait will function no differently to a neurotypical brain, but may be affected by circumstances. In example, I am good at making conversation (language). But I get sensory overload in loud and crowded spaces, which then makes conversation very hard for me.





And so, another autistic person might be very happy in loud crowds, but find conversation hard in general.



You could say I'm just a real 'party animal'!

You can see with this spectrum than, that not every autistic person has 'savant skills'. Or that someone who can't communicate verbally might still understand what you're saying, but just need a different way to communicate, such as sign language.



It shows how not every autistic person acts the same way, and we are all capable of varying strengths and weaknesses.





Sometimes, if someone is diagnosed as being 'on the spectrum', and informs another person of this, it's so that they can get some understanding and respect for the things they are unable to do.

But, it is also so that they can cooperate with the world around them- so that they can be the *best* in the things they *can* do.

I hope that in the future, people will better understand the term 'spectrum', and continue to respect the differences *and* similarities we all share in how we experience the world.

